

Matt Zerella Autobiography:

The following text is the autobiography of a man named Matt Zerella, written in the first-person

Early Life: I was born in New Hyde Park, New York on February 5th, 1990 to two parents - William and Nancy Zerella. We lived in New York until 1994, when we moved to a small town outside of Baltimore, Maryland for 3 years. In 1997 we moved to Los Gatos, California. I grew up in Silicon Valley and would spend the next 20 years of my life there, with the exception of 2007-2009 when I attended Babson College in Boston.

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Work Experience:

Google Offers:

The first job I had after graduating from Santa Clara University in 2011 was at Google at the Mountain View campus as an associate analyst on the Google Offers team. Google Offers was a relatively short-lived Google product that was analogous to Groupon and designed to compete with the burst of daily deal-type platforms that emerged around that time. My job on the team was very much a junior analyst-type job where I and my pod of colleagues were tasked with determining which markets Google Offers should focus on, which areas in those markets specifically, and evaluating the types of deals that we were offering merchants (typically cosmetics businesses, restaurants, recreational activities, etc) based on past performance. Our team's highest-level goal was to ensure that when we ran a deal with a merchant, both sides made money. The greatest difficulty was working with the merchants, not because they were difficult to work with per se, but because small business owners are a very busy, exhausted, beleaguered class of people who often work long hours 7 days a week and are in many cases (at least at that point in time) not as tech savvy as the employees of Google with whom they were corresponding.

Google Helpouts:

Eventually Google decided to kill off the Offers team because it wasn't producing much revenue and it could essentially be automated to run at a minimal level, so I was transferred to Helpouts, which was a relatively short-lived platform that Google launched whereby individual users of the platform could take "Helpout" lessons on anything from piano playing to wood carving. Our team's job was to ingest requests to join on the teaching side, and if they qualified, to get them onboarded, and also to help solve the myriad technical problems that they encountered along the way. This was much more of a client-services oriented position and while that was enjoyable, the platform had an enormous amount of technical problems and additionally suffered from a lack of marketing, so it was eventually dissolved.

Milestone Internet Marketing:

Similarly to Google Offers, Google Helpouts also failed as a product at Google and was completely dissolved. After that experience, I had learned that unless I was either an engineer, or on one of the the search or advertising product teams at Google, I would continue to be batted around like a ping pong ball in a hurricane, as Google, despite it's size, continually spun up new product teams at an alarming frequency and would dissolve them just as readily. When my role at Helpouts was dissolved, rather than wait for a few months to be placed on a different team, I took a role at a small digital marketing agency in Santa Clara called Milestone. Milestone was a full-service digital agency, but still a relatively small mom-and-pop operation that focused specifically on clients in the travel and hospitality space, namely hotels and resorts, but there were a few other travel agencies in the portfolio as well.

My role at Milestone was as an Account Manager - I inherited a book of clients for whom I launch, manage, and report on campaigns across SEO (Search Engine Optimization), PPC, and Social Media. During the year and a half that I worked at Milestone I learned an enormous amount about the underpinnings of internet marketing and how various methods of developing an online presence worked under the hood. It was an incredibly edifying experience, and it was during this time that I realized I had a knack for client-services. I've always been comfortable on the phone and in meetings, but also with crunching numbers, developing plans, and executing them. I enjoyed watching my clients numbers increase, and it gave me a rush to report on a successful campaign and hear how pleased my clients were with the job that I was doing.

The most important learning experiences came, however, in the form of difficult clients who were either hard to please or to work with for one reason or another, and it stretched my diplomatic resolve in numerous cases. Those situations helped me grow thicker skin and also learn how to negotiate from a position of strength, to stand my ground in meetings with angry people across the table or on the other end of the phone from me, and ultimately how to turn a troubling situation into a positive one.

Eventually I realized that there was a limit to how much I could grow at such a small agency, and at the same time my old manager at Google reached out to me with an opportunity that required the same skills that I had been building at Milestone, so I took it and moved on back to Google.

Google Hotel Ads:

My final role at Google was more eCommerce-focused on the Hotel Ads team, where I was a Technical Account Manager and managed the paid ad campaigns that large online travel agencies (OTAs) would run with Google. Some of my clients there included hotels.com and Priceline, which were spending quite a large amount of money with Google and there were several high-pressure initiatives that I worked on with them.

The role comprised 1) Getting new agencies onboarded, 2) Setting up their PPC (Pay Per Click) ad campaigns, 3) Managing the campaigns according to the wishes of the client, 4) Reporting on campaign KPIs (Key Performance Indicators), 5) Solving intermittent problems, and 6) Ensuring that clients were properly notified, educated, and on board with the technical changes that Hotel Ads would make to the platform at punctuated intervals.

After a little over a year in this role, however, I started to get itchy feet. There was nothing wrong with the role itself, my performance was fine, but I became disillusioned with my life there for several reasons:

- 1) The internal politics at Google started to get on my nerves. The company was so large that getting things done across large teams took a long time, and there was a blind adherence to policies that in many cases did not make sense.
- 2) I started to hate working in an office, especially the open floor plan pods that we were oriented in. I was still only 24 at this point, I'd begun to have some deep psychological awakenings regarding the purpose of working for a living, I'd traveled around enough to know that there was more to live than spending the next 10 years at this company simply to make money, and when I looked around at the people who were in positions above me, I had no desire to be anything like them.
- 3) I started to become weary of the digital whack-a-mole nature of the job, where it became essentially to do the same thing over and over again, solving the same problems day in and day out. I wanted to work in a more creative capacity that involved more autonomy, but finding that type of position as a young, relatively inexperienced person in a big company wasn't feasible

xAd/GroundTruth:

As a result of the existential crisis that I had while working at Google, I left in mid-2015 for a similar job at an advertising tech agency in San Francisco, which ended up being exactly the experience I needed to make an even bigger change for myself. I worked in one, very modestly sized room with 15 other people, cranking out powerpoint for the sales team and helping run the localized ad campaigns that the company's proprietary technology underpinned. It didn't take me long to realize that the tech we were peddling was mediocre at best and snake oil at worst. That, combined with the grueling 2-hour one-way commute via bike and train from San Jose to San Francisco every day wore me out extremely fast.

Going into the role I thought that an advertising tech firm would combine the best aspects of both advertising and tech - that it would be both creative and scrappy. As it turned out, the company actually combined both of the worst aspects: the soullessness of advertising with the Cult-like nature of tech startups.

At that point, cannabis was currently being legalized recreationally in Oregon, Washington, and Colorado, the first cohort of states to do so, and being a long-time fan of the cannabis plant itself I decided to leave my role at xAd, sell almost all my things, and move up to Hood River, Oregon.

Hood River - Fiddle Farms:

In April 2016 I started working at Fiddle Farms, a quaint permaculture homestead sitting on a beautiful 7 acre patch of land nestled in a gulch along the Hood River. I moved there because I wanted to work in the cannabis industry, as it showed a lot of promise for any aspiring entrepreneur and I intended to parlay my passion for horticulture and mind-expanding substances with my experience in tech and build a niche for myself. First, though, I needed to understand the cannabis plant at a fundamental level by learning to grow it, because I believe that the best way to understand anything is to familiarize oneself with it at its most basic level.

I arrived at the decision to work at Fiddle Farms via a program called WWOOF (Willing Workers On Organic Farms), which is essentially a work-trade arrangement by which workers are given food and shelter in exchange for doing farm work.

The work that I did in Hood River widely varied, but consisted of building greenhouses, running irrigation, growing fruits and vegetables from seed and propagation, taking care of animals including goats, geese, chickens, ducks, and rabbits. We also set up a 3000 square foot cannabis grow operation on the farm, which was obviously the work that I was most excited about. Over the course of the 8 months that I worked there, I learned a massive amount about how to grow food sustainably, soil science, various methods of cultivating cannabis, and most importantly, I rediscovered deep truths about myself that I had lost throughout my university experience and the ensuing 5 years of working in tech.

Those truths were including, but not limited to:

- I have a deep, abiding love for the natural world and the manner in which it is organized
- I am and will always be an entrepreneur and a self-starter to my core
- I can deal with a great amount of chaos and struggle in order to achieve the things in life that I desire
- I love working with people and solving problems, and I am skilled at both
- The learning process is my favorite part of any new endeavor
- My physical and emotional health is more important to me than money

Cannabis Industry Experience:

I left the farm in Hood River at the end of the agricultural season in Winter 2016 and moved to Portland where I worked at several different dispensaries over the course of the next few months. I took these jobs because I wanted to develop a b2b eCommerce platform for the cannabis industry which would allow dispensaries to purchase their products wholesale online rather than through a messy network of distributors, and it was necessary for me to understand what that purchasing process looked like on the ground.

In 2017 my friend Donovan and I founded Bloom, raised a small amount of friends and family capital, and built an MVP over the course of the next year. At the same time, I worked for a small cannabis distributor in Portland, but moved back to California in August of 2017 when RVR Distributing offered me a job doing the same thing but for higher pay. At that point Cannabis had just been legalized in California. I wasn't necessarily ready to leave Portland but it made the most sense to me at the time.

At the time, RVR was one of the largest Cannabis distributors in California, with a portfolio of over 30 brands. I was given a struggling territory - Santa Cruz - but immediately started to see results as I drove from store to store getting samples to main key holders at each account, educating them on the products, negotiating placement deals, and solving problems that had clearly been unaddressed by my predecessor. Over the course of the next year, I grew that territory by 3x and was given the San Jose territory as well.

The cannabis industry in California in 2017 was a fascinating environment for a young, hungry entrepreneur like myself - it felt so utterly wide open and full of possibilities due to the fact that there was a massive amount of money and people pouring in from all over the country, there was a Cambrian explosion of new products and methods by which the cannabis plant could be

processed into new consumable forms, and because the regulations were still being drafted, there was a very palpable 'Wild West' spirit in the air. Looking back 2017-2019 were the best years of my life - I was making more money than I ever had, I felt like I'd finally found my niche, an industry that rewarded scrappy, independent, goal-oriented individuals like myself who were willing to put in the work, and a product that was easy for me to represent and sell.

After a year of working at RVR I was poached from them by Flow Kana, a rising star in the industry that stood for everything that RVR didn't. RVR was helmed by Ted Simpkins Sr., a corporate marauder from the wine and spirits industry who had an ugly reputation as a ruthless robber-baron type businessman and who clearly had no affinity for the cannabis plant or the legacy that it had in California. By contrast, Flow Kana's business was built on uniting the hundreds of legacy cannabis growers in the Emerald Triangle (Mendocino, Humboldt, and Trinity Counties) and helping them transition their outdated businesses to the new recreational paradigm. All of these growers had learned to run their farms sustainably, using minimal inputs, and working in harmony with the parameters of the land that they lived upon. It was perfectly in line with the life that I had lived on the farm in Oregon, so when they offered me a job I took it immediately. I was able to transfer a strong book of business to them as well, so I found immediate success and proceeded to grow my territory by 10x over the course of the next few years.

Flow Kana Cannabis Experience (2018 - 2022):

I spent 4 years working at Flow Kana, which makes it the longest-held job of my life, and it was a rollercoaster ride from start to finish. At its peak, my territory was generating \$450,000 every month for the company, which made me the highest-performing sales person at the #1 Cannabis Flower brand in the state. Flow Kana was ranked as the #1 Cannabis Flower brand in California for 25 consecutive months, and during that time I definitely felt like I was on top of the world. Our product - sustainably sourced Cannabis flower from the legacy growers in Northern California - was incredibly popular, and I was able to negotiate strong deals with dispensary chains who historically had only purchased indoor cannabis flower, which is significantly less sustainable and much more expensive to produce. My day-to-day role responsibilities consisted of having meetings with account key holders to discuss product performance, launching new products, representing the company at trade conferences and events, working with the production team to incorporate market feedback into successive iterations of the product, ensuring that bills were paid, orders were delivered, product was displayed properly, and most importantly that accounts and customers were happy with our product.

During that time I was also working on my eCommerce B2B marketplace, Bloom, and I had high aspirations of getting Flow Kana to be the marquee user and leveraging Flow Kana's distribution network to power the platform's delivery service. Things were looking very positive for quite some time, but when the pandemic hit in March of 2020, Flow Kana began a precipitous downturn that it would never recover from.

There are many reasons why this happened, including but not limited to:

- People could no longer smell the cannabis product on display. This hurt Flow Kana more than most companies in the space because outdoor Cannabis flower has a much stronger smell profile than indoor flower, which is its primary selling point. Cannabis flower smells the way that it does due to Terpenes (organic compounds that give plants their scent and in

nature serve to attract pollinators and deter pests), which also has a significant impact of the cognitive effect of consuming cannabis.

- My colleagues and I could no longer visit the stores that sold our product, and it caused us to grow disconnected from increasingly negative feedback from individual customers due to corners that were being cut in the production process and also areas where our competitors were beating us. By the time that the lockdowns were lifted, the damage had been done
- Flow Kana wasted an enormous amount of money on frivolous expenditures, including expensive rockstar executives and ineffective mass marketing campaigns. By the time Flow Kana officially went bankrupt in January of 2022, the company had burnt through over \$300 million in funding
- The supply chain that Flow Kana had built was predicated on unit economics that didn't scale, so when our competitors started to scale up grow operations, they were able to produce better quality flower at a much lower price than Flow Kana. To my credit, I warned many people about this years in advance, but I was repeatedly told that it would 'dilute the brand'.

Post-Flow Kana:

Alas, as the saying goes, 'good times never last', and in 2022 after 18 months of dismal sales, Flow Kana filed for bankruptcy and I was laid off. In the intervening period I had also realized that Donovan and I, despite the validity of our idea for Bloom, were not going to be able to succeed in that venture because the cannabis industry had shown itself to be far less lucrative of an opportunity than we previously thought, primarily due to the fact that it was strangled by government regulations which made doing business in the same way that other retail verticals do completely out of the question. Over the past 3 years I have been continually shown that our idea for Bloom had a ton of merit, which has been encouraging, but it also became readily apparent in 2021 that if we wanted to weather the storm as the industry bucked and rolled its way through very intense growing pains, we would have needed to raise around \$2M, which was way out of reach for us at the time. So, we folded Bloom about 6 months before Flow Kana went bust.

After Flow Kana, I spun my wheels for a few months, because I felt that I no longer had purpose. The cannabis industry had turned out to be something that I never wanted to be a part of, which was a very stereotypical CPG (consumer packaged goods) industry similar to granola bars and soda pop, it was a race to the bottom in which whomever had the biggest marketing budget would win. I wanted to be a part of the Cannabis industry because I thought it would be lucrative, but I also thought that it would contribute to society in a more creative, constructive way, open the door to more research about the inner workings of the human brain, creativity, humor, emotions, our perception of time, etc., but it wound up being much more shallow than I ever expected. Once I see something, I can't really unsee it, so I resolved to find another career. In 2022, however, that proved to be a little more difficult than I expected, and when my former VP of Sales contacted me for another Account Manager role at a small cannabis brand called Garden Society, I took it.

Garden Society:

Garden Society is a small, women-owned cannabis brand based in Santa Rosa, CA, and my work there was very similar to the work that I was doing at Flow Kana, except for the fact that

Garden Society was struggling, had never been a top brand, and suffered equally from attempting to adhere to a set of niche brand tenets while trying to reconcile the founders' desires to be a top-10 brand in California with their unwillingness to take on sufficient funding to do so. As a result, we were understaffed, under equipped to compete in an increasingly price-sensitive, oversaturated industry, and projects either fizzled out into nothing or took forever to complete. I did the best I could and grew my territory by 3x at it's peak, but I was again laid off in February 2024 as the company prepared to exit California.

Current Career Break:

I am currently living in Oakland, and at the time of this writing I have been unemployed for 8 months, 6 of which I have spent studying python as it pertains to the construction and application of machine learning and A.I. models. After I was laid off, I again took a couple months to consider what I wanted to do next, but it was a fairly easy decision for me to make considering that the cannabis industry had declined even further since my last layoff 2 years prior, and new advances in A.I. had taken the world by storm. Additionally, I started playing around with Stable Diffusion back in October 2023 and I was immediately captivated, but I also realized that if I wanted to be able to use image generation models well, I would need to understand how they work, so I started learning.

In March I started having conversations with people in my network about how realistic it would be for me to skill up my computer science and programming knowledge to the point where I might be a valuable addition to a company producing an A.I. product or incorporating A.I. into an existing product. I received a resounding "yes!" From every single person I spoke to, the majority of whom were either executives, engineers, or both. I was told that, because the pace of advancement in the field and due to the fact that pure python scripting was rapidly being abstracted away by new libraries and frameworks, if I studied python diligently for 4-5 months I could get myself up to speed. I wouldn't be ready for a full-blown A.I. engineer job, but I would be able to contribute meaningfully to A.I. and M.L. (Machine Learning) projects.

My journey to learning Python, Machine Learning, and A.I.:

My personal approach to learning new subject matter is something that I think sets me apart from the majority of people, and it goes something like this:

- Start with a well-defined goal. This CANNOT be something like "learn XYZ", because that is too open-ended. In this situation, it was more like "Learn to build coding projects using Machine Learning models"
- Speak to as many people as I can about how they would suggest I go about achieving this goal, and dive into the resources that they give me
- Try and see if I can accomplish the goal that I have set for myself, but with basically no experience. This is important because it gives me a sense of how far I have to go. This also includes reading articles and tutorials.
- Once I am sure that A) this goal can be accomplished, B) that it is within reach for me personally, and C) that learning resources exist out there for me to use, I start with the fundamentals.
 - For music, this was scales, muscle memory, and music theory
 - For Cannabis, this was learning to grow the plant itself and learning everything I could about what goes into the raw materials
 - For machine learning, this was learning Python basics and doing leetcode exercises

- The most interesting part for me in the learning process is the pivot. This is when I realize that I need to move on from one subject to another, despite the fact that I haven't learned every single thing about that subject matter yet. For programming, this was when I realized that it would take me a year of just grinding leetcode to get to the place where I could do Hard level problems.
- Another critical part of the learning process for me is leaving a subject matter when I get to a place where I need to learn something else in order to move forward. This happened for me several times while learning machine learning.
 - For example, one of the first courses that I took was an Introduction to Programming with Python 101 from MIT Online, but I realized early on that I needed to start with a much more basic python class, so I took a few on Udemy. By the time that I went back to the MIT course, it was a breeze.
 - Another example is a course specialization that I took from online Stanford via Deeplearning.ai and Coursera. It was incredibly interesting, but again I realized that if I was going to truly understand the subject matter and get the most out of the course, I would need to get much better at Python and take some online courses on how to program machine learning models.
- The next step in my learning process is to do what I call 'painting by numbers', which is where I do the type of thing that I am learning, but essentially by following instructions.
- Next, I start to find people who are better than I am that I can talk to about what I'm learning. I have found that building this network, combined with the 'paint by numbers' approach, creates a powerful feedback loop that serves to encourage me through difficult points in the journey, and it also makes everything much more fun. I have also built great friendships as a result of this approach.

As a result of this approach to learning, after 6 months of diligent studying, I've built several predictive machine learning models that are hosted in Jupyter Notebooks, I've built 2 chatbots, including 1 chatbot that utilizes RAG (Retrieval Augmented Generation), and I am in the process of building a third chatbot. I've also started a small 'thinktank' with 2 of my friends where we share our thoughts on new advancements in A.I. over the messaging app Slack and brainstorm how we might apply them.

My Current Career Aspirations:

My short term career aspirations are twofold:

- 1) I want to leverage my past experience in client-services, and
- 2) I want to be a part of building an A.I. solution that I personally find compelling, either because it is simply fun and interesting, because it benefits society, or because it solves an interesting problem.

Ultimately this means that the type of role I am searching for will be either a Technical Account Manger, Account Manger, Solutions Architect, Project Manager, or something similar, which would require solid soft-skills to work cross-functionally, ensure that projects move forward and important stakeholders are satisfied, but also some technical understanding of A.I. systems and the ability to patch issues, provide customer feedback to engineers, and communicate important aspects of the product to non-technical customers or stakeholders.

My experience in advertising tech and in Cannabis - both nascent, fast-moving, hypergrowth spaces - will make me a valuable asset at any company that is operating in the A.I. space and is currently going to market, thus needing team members with both soft and hard skills.

In the long term, I want to increase my ability to build A.I. systems, improve my programming abilities, and either move to a full engineering role or a much more advanced multidisciplinary role where I can help strike deals between companies the same way I did at Flow Kana, and also contribute to the development and deployment of new products.

My biggest priority in a new role, besides being a member of a strong team, is learning more about how generative A.I. systems are deployed at scale. As much as I love learning at my own pace, being surrounded by smart people who know more than I do is my favorite way to learn quickly.

Matt's Resume:

MATTHEW ZERELLA

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About Me: Resilient client-services veteran with deep sales experience and a well-rounded skillset honed over 12+ years spent at hypergrowth startups in fast-moving, nascent industries. Self-taught python developer focusing on Gen A.I. and Machine Learning.

Desired Role: My combination of skills will add value to any role or company which could benefit from a team player with the soft-skills of an account or project manager along with the technical knowledge to solve client problems on the fly and contribute meaningfully to product development. Ideal company is going to market with a product that is either A.I. or ML-centric, or is incorporating either to support an existing product.

SOFT SKILLS

- Proven ability to learn new skills under pressure
- Creative problem-solving on a deadline
- Maintaining strong client relationships
- Minimizing the impact of negative circumstances on client relationships
- Explaining complex concepts in a digestible manner
- Effective and flexible communication
- Confident presenting deliverables to C-suite decision makers
- Ability to work cross-functionally
- Familiarity with using new A.I. tools to increase productivity

EDUCATION:

- Data Science & Machine Learning Specialization via Stanford Online and Deeplearning.ai (2024)
- Zero-To-Mastery computer science bootcamp (Data Science and LLM- powered app development (2024
- Santa Clara University (B.A. Communications: 2011)

HARD SKILLS

- Python •
- Building and optimizing Machine Learning algorithms •

- Dataset manipulation and analysis •
- Fine-tuning Large Language Models •
- LLM and Generative A.I.- powered applications •
- Fast and effective research skills •
- LLM Prompting

TOOL COMPETENCIES

- AI/ML frameworks (e.g. Tensorflow, Transformers)
- Vector DBs (Chroma, Pinecone)
- Streamlit
- Langchain
- Docker
- AWS

A.I. & MACHINE LEARNING: 2024

Developed a self-imposed computer science curriculum with the goals of 1) learning Python programming related to the use of machine learning and language models, and 2) building applications and models that utilize the most recent advancements in the field.

- LLM-powered RAG application
- Reliable predictive machine learning models for bulldozer pricing, heart disease, image classification, and loan approval
- Llama 3.1 8 billion parameter model fine-tuned on a finance-dataset

CANNABIS: 2016 - 2024

Drove significant growth for several brands and distributors via effective management of a vast range of personality types, legal difficulties, and changing regulations. Supported supply chain development, fostered consumer education, and engineered deals that ensured strong client relationships

Garden Society (2023 - 2024): NorCal Sales Manager

Flow Kana (2018 - 2022): Sr. Account Manager

RVR Distributing (2017 - 2018): Account Manager

Busy Bee Distributing: Account Manager (2017)

★ Drove key internal branding and product initiatives

Grew accounts by 3x in first year

Spearheaded 12 new product launches and multiple key internal QA/QC improvements

★ Grew accounts 10x over entire tenure

★ Managed dozens of new product and brand launches as the industry transitioned from medical to recreational in 2017

★ Grew accounts by 2x in first year

★ Managed distribution relationships with over 400 legal dispensaries across Oregon

TECH: 2011 - 2015

Focused on designing and optimizing digital advertising campaigns while keeping pace with rapid developments in ad targeting technologies and SEO

xAd (2015):

Account Planner

★ Supported sales and product teams by delivering key campaign insights to clients and ensuring ad campaigns were set up for success to reliably hit KPIs

Milestone (2012 - 2013): ★ Account Manager

Google (2011-2012, 2014-2015) ★ Technical Account Manager

Developed and executed 360-degree marketing campaigns for large travel industry clients while managing key account relationships generating over \$500k/year
Supported technical ads implementation and managed key partner relationships generating revenue over \$2M/year